strength of the Senate and three members of the District of Columbia). A candidate in order to win the Presidential election needs 270 votes, that is, 269 (half of the total votes of 538) plus one.

It must be stressed here that the members of the electoral college are not the members of the Congress. The college is a special body which is formed only for electing the President and it gets dissolved after this.

If no candidate secures the requisite majority, the House of Representatives elects the President from among the three candidates securing the highest votes in the electoral college. There have been three such occasions (1800, 1824 and 1876).

Qualifications, Term and Removal According to the Constitution, a candidate for the presidency must have the following three qualifications:

(i) He/she must be a natural born citizen of the USA. A naturalised citizen is not eligible.

(ii) He/she must have attained the age of thirty-five years.

(iii) He/she must have been a resident of the USA for fourteen years (not necessarily consecutive).

The President holds the office for a fixed tenure of four years. He/she is eligible for re-election but only once. The 22nd Amendment Act of 1951 has fixed the maximum total term for any President at ten years. In other words, it bars any person from being elected as President more than twice. The Presidential term of four years begins on 20th January.

The President may be removed from the office before the expiry of his/her normal tenure of four years through impeachment for treason, bribery or other high crimes and misdemeanors. The House of Representatives initiates the impeachment proceedings by a majority vote. The case is then tried by the Senate. During this trial period, the Senate acts as a judicial tribunal and is presided over by the chief justice of the Supreme Court (and not the vice-President). If the Senate also passes the impeachment resolution by a two-thirds majority, the President stands impeached. So far, no American President has ever been removed by impeachment. However, there have been five impeachment attempts — Andrew Johnson (1868), Richard Nixon (1974), Bill Clinton (1998), Donald Trump (first time in 2019) and Donald Trump (second time in 2021).

Powers and Functions The American presidency is one of the strongest democratic offices in the world. Lord Bryce regards it as 'the greatest office in the world'. Munro observed, "the American President exercises the largest amount of authority ever wielded by any man in a democracy". Ogg regards him/her as "the greatest ruler of the world". Harold Laski remarked, "the President of the United States is both more and less than a King, he/she is also both more and less than a Prime Minister".

The President derives his/her powers and functions from four sources: Constitution, statutes of Congress, judicial interpretations and political conventions. These are mentioned below:

1. He/she has to enforce the Constitution, federal laws and treaties, and judicial decisions throughout the country.

2. He/she is the supreme commander of the armed forces of the US.

3. He/she appoints the Supreme Court judges, ambassadors, heads of executive departments, diplomatic officials, consuls and other top officials.